The Phrasebook

Thirty-six words that sound like a promise on a label, with what each one is meant to make you think — and what it actually tells you.

FREE · PRINT IT · PASS IT ON · 10 PAGES

An educational reference. Not legal advice, and not a certification of anything.

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The Phrasebook

Read part one once. Keep part two for when you meet a word you do not trust.

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PART ONE

Six habits

You do not need to memorise anything. You need six habits, and each takes about a minute once it is a habit.

01 Read the certification, not the colour

Green packaging, leaf motifs and kraft-paper texture are design choices, not evidence. Look for a named certification with a licence number. If the only green thing about it is the box, that is your answer.

02 Ask what the word excludes

“Cage-free” tells you about cages and nothing else. “Cruelty-free” says nothing about whether the product contains animal ingredients. Every one of these terms is narrow, and the value is in knowing exactly how narrow.

03 Look for a number

“Made with recycled materials” is a feeling. “80% post-consumer recycled” is a fact. Brands that have the number print the number. Brands that do not, do not.

04 Find the baseline in comparative claims

“Greener”, “better”, “more sustainable” — than what? If the comparison is not stated, there usually isn’t one.

05 Check who says so

A brand’s own “we care” page is a claim about itself. A third-party certification is an audited standard someone else can be held to. The two are not the same kind of statement.

06 Assume nothing about the parent company

A small ethical brand is often owned by a large group with a very different record. Ownership is public information and takes two minutes to check.

PART TWO

36 words, decoded

These are the terms that do the most work on packaging and carry the least. For each: what you are meant to think, what it tells you, and where that reading comes from.

GENERAL

Natural

YOU'LL THINK — Often implies "good for you" or "safe", suggesting wholesome plant origin.

IT MEANS — **In most jurisdictions there is no legal definition of "natural" in cosmetics or food labelling. Arsenic, lead, and poison ivy are also "natural".**

SOURCE — US FTC: "no clear definition"; EU food law: no harmonised meaning.

Eco-friendly

YOU'LL THINK — The product is gentle on the environment.

IT MEANS — **Considered too vague to substantiate by the US FTC. The Green Guides require any environmental claim be qualified with what specifically is eco-friendly and how.**

SOURCE — FTC Green Guides §260.4.

Sustainable

YOU'LL THINK — Doesn't harm the environment over time.

IT MEANS — **No regulatory definition. The UN Brundtland definition is "meeting the needs of the present without compromising future generations" — meaningless as a product label.**

SOURCE — UN Brundtland Commission (1987).

Locally sourced

YOU'LL THINK — Came from nearby.

IT MEANS — **No regulatory definition of "local". Some EU/UK retailers define it as within 30 miles or within county — but the term on packaging is unregulated.**

SOURCE — UK ASA case law.

Greener / More sustainable

YOU'LL THINK — Less harmful than the alternative.

IT MEANS — **Comparative claims require disclosure of the comparison basis. "Greener than what?" "More sustainable than which version?" — must be substantiated.**

SOURCE — FTC Green Guides §260.4; UK CMA Green Claims Code 2021.

Conscious / Mindful

YOU'LL THINK — Thoughtfully made.

IT MEANS — **Marketing language only. No regulatory meaning. The UK ASA and EU Green Claims Directive both flag these as unsubstantiated vagueness.**

SOURCE — EU Green Claims Directive (2023 proposal).

Small-batch / Artisan

YOU'LL THINK Handmade in tiny, careful quantities.

IT MEANS No definition of 'small' or 'artisan'. Large manufacturers use these terms freely to imply craft and care.

SOURCE No regulatory standard.

CLIMATE & ENERGY

Carbon-neutral

YOU'LL THINK The company has zero net carbon emissions.

IT MEANS Almost always achieved through carbon offsets, not actual emission reductions. Many offset schemes have been investigated for over-claiming. The EU proposes banning the term unless backed by science-based reductions.

SOURCE EU Green Claims Directive (2023 proposal); Guardian/Die Zeit/SourceMaterial Verra investigation (2023).

Net-zero

YOU'LL THINK Net carbon emissions of zero.

IT MEANS Usually depends on offsets and assumed future negative-emissions technology. The SBTi Net-Zero Standard sets criteria (90%+ absolute reduction by 2050) but few corporate "net-zero" claims meet it.

SOURCE Science Based Targets initiative (SBTi).

Made with renewable energy

YOU'LL THINK The factory runs on solar/wind etc.

IT MEANS May refer to purchased Renewable Energy Certificates (RECs) that don't actually power the factory. Look for guarantees of additionality and physical delivery.

SOURCE EU Green Claims Directive (2023 proposal).

Reef-safe

YOU'LL THINK This sunscreen won't harm coral reefs.

IT MEANS There is no standardised or regulated definition of 'reef-safe'. Check the actual filters — avoid oxybenzone and octinoxate rather than trusting the label.

SOURCE US NOAA / Hawaii Act 104.

Climate positive / Climate neutral

YOU'LL THINK The product removes more carbon than it emits.

IT MEANS Almost always relies on offsets rather than actual removals, and 'positive' claims are even harder to substantiate than 'neutral' ones. The EU proposes restricting both.

SOURCE EU Green Claims Directive (2023 proposal).

Palm-oil free

YOU'LL THINK Contains no palm oil, so it's better for forests.

IT MEANS Sometimes true, but replacements (coconut, soy, shea) can need MORE land. Certified sustainable palm (RSPO) can be a lower-impact choice than a blanket boycott.

SOURCE IUCN Palm Oil Task Force 2018.

PACKAGING & WASTE

Biodegradable

YOU'LL THINK The product breaks down naturally and harmlessly.

IT MEANS Must be qualified — biodegradable under what conditions? Within what timeframe? Most "biodegradable" plastics require industrial composting (60°C+) which most consumers cannot access.

SOURCE FTC Green Guides §260.8; EU EN 13432 standard.

Compostable

YOU'LL THINK You can compost the packaging at home.

IT MEANS Usually means industrially compostable, not home-compostable. Distinguish between BPI / TUV "OK Compost HOME" certification and "OK Compost INDUSTRIAL".

SOURCE EU EN 13432 (industrial); EN 17427 (home).

Recyclable

YOU'LL THINK This product can be recycled.

IT MEANS Only meaningful if recycling facilities for the specific material are available to most consumers in your region. Theoretically recyclable ≠ practically recycled. Globally, less than 9% of all plastic ever made has been recycled.

SOURCE OECD Global Plastics Outlook 2022.

Ocean-bound plastic

YOU'LL THINK Made from plastic rescued from the sea.

IT MEANS Usually means plastic collected within ~50 km of a coastline — not from the ocean itself. Definitions vary by certifier and are often generous.

SOURCE Zero Plastic Oceans / OBP certification.

Made with recycled materials

YOU'LL THINK The product is recycled.

IT MEANS Can mean as little as 1% recycled content. Look for a stated percentage and whether it is post-consumer (used by people) or pre-consumer (factory offcuts).

SOURCE ISO 14021 / FTC Green Guides.

Tree-free

YOU'LL THINK No trees were cut for this paper.

IT MEANS Can be true (bamboo, sugarcane bagasse) but doesn't address the water, land, or transport footprint of the alternative crop. Verify the whole picture.

SOURCE FTC Green Guides §260.4.

ANIMALS

Cruelty-free

YOU'LL THINK No animals were harmed.

IT MEANS Not legally defined globally. May refer to the finished product but not individual ingredients, or only to the manufacturer's own labs not third-party testing. Look for Leaping Bunny or PETA Beauty Without Bunnies certification.

SOURCE EU Cosmetics Reg banned animal-tested cosmetics from sale since 2013; cruelty-free labelling unregulated.

Vegan

YOU'LL THINK — Contains no animal-derived ingredients.

IT MEANS — In cosmetics, not legally defined — but a "vegan" label generally means no animal-derived ingredients. It does NOT mean cruelty-free.

SOURCE — Vegan Society / Vegan Action certification.

Free-range

YOU'LL THINK — Animals roamed freely outdoors.

IT MEANS — In the EU, "free-range" eggs require 4m² per hen of outdoor access — but only theoretical access; many never go outside. For meat, the term is less regulated. UK definitions are similar.

SOURCE — EU Reg 589/2008 (eggs); UK DEFRA.

Cage-free

YOU'LL THINK — Hens roam freely, not in cages.

IT MEANS — Means hens are uncaged inside a barn — not that they go outdoors or have much space. Distinct from free-range or pasture-raised.

SOURCE — EU Reg 589/2008; RSPCA Assured standards.

Humanely raised

YOU'LL THINK — Animals had good welfare.

IT MEANS — Not legally defined in most markets. Meaningful only with a third-party welfare certification (e.g. RSPCA Assured, Certified Humane, GAP).

SOURCE — No regulatory standard.

LABOUR & SOCIAL

Fair trade

YOU'LL THINK — Workers received fair wages and conditions.

IT MEANS — Several certifications exist (Fairtrade International, Fair Trade USA, World Fair Trade Organization) with different standards. "Fair trade" without certification is meaningless.

SOURCE — Fairtrade International standards.

Ethically sourced

YOU'LL THINK — Materials and labour meet fair standards.

IT MEANS — No legal definition and no required certification. Without a named standard (Fairtrade, SA8000, WFTO) it is an unverifiable marketing phrase.

SOURCE — UK CMA Green Claims Code 2021.

Responsibly sourced

YOU'LL THINK — Sourcing considers people and planet.

IT MEANS — Undefined and self-declared. 'Responsible' sets no measurable bar — ask: responsible to whom, verified by whom?

SOURCE — EU Green Claims Directive (2023 proposal).

FOOD

Plant-based

YOU'LL THINK — Made primarily from plants.

IT MEANS — No regulatory threshold. "Plant-based" can mean 100% plant or "contains some plants" depending on the product.

SOURCE — FDA: no enforced definition.

Organic

YOU'LL THINK — Grown without synthetic chemicals.

IT MEANS — Legally defined in EU and US — requires certification (USDA Organic, EU Organic logo). The term itself, alone, on a product is regulated. But "organic" cosmetic claims are less tightly controlled.

SOURCE — EU Reg 2018/848; USDA NOP.

Grass-fed

YOU'LL THINK — The animal ate only grass, on pasture.

IT MEANS — In many markets animals may be 'grass-fed' yet grain-finished, or fed grass indoors. '100% grass-fed' and pasture certifications are stricter.

SOURCE — USDA (withdrew its grass-fed standard in 2016).

BEAUTY & PERSONAL CARE

Clean / Clean beauty

YOU'LL THINK — Free of harmful or "bad" ingredients.

IT MEANS — No regulatory definition. Each retailer (Sephora, Credo, Ulta) sets its own "clean" criteria — they don't agree with each other.

SOURCE — No regulatory standard.

Non-toxic

YOU'LL THINK — Will not cause harm.

IT MEANS — Dose-dependent and undefined. The FTC Green Guides require substantiation for non-toxic claims; the EU has prohibited the unqualified use of "non-toxic" on detergents and cleaning products.

SOURCE — FTC Green Guides §260.10; EU Detergents Regulation.

Chemical-free

YOU'LL THINK — Contains no chemicals.

IT MEANS — Scientifically impossible — water is a chemical. The term is meaningless and flagged as misleading by regulators.

SOURCE — UK ASA rulings; EU Green Claims Directive.

Dermatologist-tested

YOU'LL THINK — Proven safe by skin doctors.

IT MEANS — Only means a dermatologist was involved in testing — not that it passed, nor how many people, nor the result. 'Tested' is not 'approved'.

SOURCE — US FDA cosmetics guidance.

Hypoallergenic

YOU'LL THINK	Won't cause allergic reactions.
IT MEANS	**No federal standard or required testing in the US. Manufacturers define it themselves. Any product can be labelled hypoallergenic.**
SOURCE	US FDA: 'no meaning'.

No nasties

YOU'LL THINK	Free from harmful ingredients.
IT MEANS	**Marketing shorthand with no definition. Each brand decides what a 'nasty' is — often to imply competitors are unsafe.**
SOURCE	UK ASA / EU Green Claims Directive.

PART THREE

What this cannot do

A phrasebook that claimed to settle every question would be doing the thing it warns you about.

It will not tell you whether a particular product is ethical. No document can. Checking one brand means reading its published policy, the scope of its certifications, where it sells and who owns it — and any answer goes out of date when a formulation or a supplier changes.

What it gives you is what each word does and does not tell you, and where that reading comes from. It takes a minute per product and produces an answer you can explain, which is worth more than one you have to trust.

LICENCE

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CORRECTIONS

If something here is wrong, we would rather hear it than not: info@feral-femme.co. Substantive corrections are published in full at feral-femme.co/corrections/, with what was said, what was wrong, and when it changed.

EDITION

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WHEN YOU WANT TO PUT IT TO WORK · FERAL-FEMME.CO/SHOP

The Brand Audit Workbook	PREMIUM	Audit a brand from the public record, in six modules.
The Claims Desk	PREMIUM	A claims review procedure and working file, for brands.
The Wardrobe & Bathroom Audit	PREMIUM	Four weeks, two rooms, and a list for what you buy next.
The Complaint Kit	PREMIUM	Ask, escalate and speak up, with a template for each step.